

ALICE IN CLUBLAND

After centuries of being ostracised, women are finally grabbing decision-making posts in India's final male frontier: the elite clubs of India. The change, though, has come not without a fight.



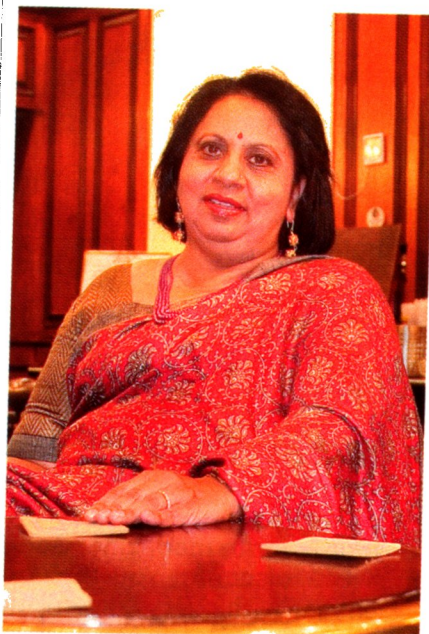
■ By Damayanti Datta

"Women and Children not allowed."
—signboard outside men's bar at the Bangalore Club

It seems ludicrous that such a sign should still be allowed to be displayed in this day and age. But such is the accepted norm in the anachronism that is India's elite clubland. Most clubs were founded by the British as male preserves, where wives were kept at a safe distance from cigars, port and clubby atmosphere. White gave way to Brown but the mindset continued. Finally, change is in the air. This September saw history being made when Renu Roy, 57, was elected the first woman president of the Saturday Club of Kolkata—one of the more liberal among those über-masculine, ultra-snob institutions.

Predictably, the news has been greeted with squeals of anguish. The president of one of the top clubs in Delhi cannot believe it: "What? A woman president of a club?" he

FIRST LADIES: (above) Roy at the Saturday Club of Kolkata, (below) Kamath at the Bangalore Club



queries, astonishment and consternation evident in his tone. He would spill his afternoon gin and tonic if he knew of the other women who are threatening the last surviving male bastion. A month earlier, in an eye-popping first in 178 years, the oldest sporting club outside the British Isles, the Royal Calcutta Golf Club, chose a lady committee member. "I was quite taken aback when they asked me to join, but I agreed immediately," says veteran golf pro, Anu Bindra. And she has already made a difference. "Earlier, women would hardly come forward to play. But ever since I got elected, the number has gone up to 25." The year 2007 is fast becoming "That Year in History". By a 99 per cent show of hands, the Calcutta Club gave voting rights to women this April. A clean break with a 100-year-old tradition.

Elsewhere, Bharathi Kamath became the first woman committee member of the 139-year-old Bangalore Club. Standing before the chauvinistic signboard outside the men's bar, she still cannot come to terms with the fact that women got voting rights only in 2001. She would be heartened to know that Shobita Saigal, 51, was the chairman of bar committee, till recently, at the Delhi Gymkhana Club. The mostly-male crowd during lunchtime at the bar may be seething into the frothy beer but their cosy world has changed forever. Those days when a woman could not become a member in her own right, are gone forever. Today, there is even a new membership category for single women. "In a club where the waiting list for membership is over 32 years, your chances are better if you are a woman," says A.S. Dulat, who just finished his term as the president.

"It's a question of survival," holds Purshottam Bhageria, the man who co-

For the first time in 200 years, a woman has been elected the president of a top-drawer club in the country.